

a core idea, and different trains of thought burst forth from there. One idea gives birth to so many more, each then resulting in another. And this is exactly what a mind map is supposed to represent: one central theme, and the links between all the various thoughts under that theme.

So rather than taking copious notes, Buzan advised students to sit down and draw these strange structures, claiming it would help them. In a mind map, rather than using full sentences, one employs key words and phrases, which are easier to remember. They can also use colours to distinguish between different lines of thought. Pictures have a way of sticking in our minds, so even though mind maps end up being chaotic, their visual representation registers better in our minds and is easier to recall.

I Want To Make One Too!

Mind maps are really easy to make—they were meant to be. How they finally end up is usually unique to the individual—the structure he uses or how he highlights his ideas—but all follow the same general idea. It all begins with the goal at the centre—the topic of a lecture, the theme of a board meeting, or an idea for your next article. You work outwards from this idea, jotting down key words, and connecting each thought to the next one in that line. If there are two lines of thought that share a relationship, make sure that you mark this link with an arrow. Ideally, a mind map is drawn very quickly, without pausing to judge or review what you've put down so far—this way your mind map becomes a truer picture of your thought processes.

The most effective mind maps are those that are heavily visual—if there is any idea you think needs some attention, make sure it gets it! Use colours, images, anything you can do to highlight it. And if one line of thought exhausts itself, just move over to the next—you can always come back

Concept Mapping

The concept map is another technique to get your thoughts out on paper in a simple, easy-to-understand way. Though it looks quite similar to the mind map, it is different in that it shows the relationships between different concepts rather than follow the hierarchical tree-like form that mind maps take. These relationships are represented by using a phrase to link the concepts—something like “is opposed to” or “is much better than”, and so on. While there is software out there built specifically for concept mapping, mind mapping software that allows for flexible structures (like Mindjet MindManager) could also be used to build concept maps.

if something strikes you later. Most of all, remember that it's *your* mind map, and you have all the freedom to make it in your own special style.

What Is It Good For?

For students, the original targets of the concept, the mind map is a very effective way to summarise information, be it notes in class or while sitting in the library studying. It also comes in handy when its time to slog it out for the exams—having everything arranged out in front of you registers better on one's mind. College life can get hectic sometimes, and a mind map could help you organise your day better—plan out lectures and study times, and perhaps things might not seem so chaotic.

Struggling with an important decision—like buying a house—but worried about whether you've thought of everything? Putting it all down on a mind map will let you look at your thoughts and help you see the bigger picture.

In the office, mind maps are a great help in brainstorming—just throw everything out on the mind map and look at it at leisure to pick out the more appealing ideas. They are also popular in meetings, where they can be used to steer discussions in definite directions rather than having everyone talking away wildly and wasting time.

It isn't just organising thoughts that mind maps are useful for. They can also be used to plan out tasks and projects, highlighting the most important aspects and assigning different tasks to different people. And it isn't just students who benefit from the visual aspect of a mind map: presentations, too, can be made effective with a mind map that shows the entire structure of the information you want to convey.

The Tech Angle

A large part of our lives is now is spent in front of the computer, and it is not hard to guess that

A Mind map one would make when buying a new house

